EU will likely scrape through winter on tighter gas reserves

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The EU will likely get through the 2026-2027 winter without resorting to emergency measures, but storage will land below the effective 80% floor, leaving the region exposed to supply disruptions or a cold snap.
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Title Transfer Facility (TTF) spot prices will likely average €45–€65 megawatt hours through the end of March as Strait of Hormuz disruptions and below-seasonal storage keep the global gas market tight.
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The Russian LNG ban will likely take effect on 1 January 2027, removing 13%–15% of EU LNG imports with the unlikely prospect of a temporary waiver.

The EU will likely get through winter without emergency measures, though the margin for error is slim. Gas storage will likely land below the EU's effective 80% floor—the 90% target is almost certainly out of reach—but should be sufficient to avoid shortages under normal conditions (65% odds). There is a 25% chance of a shortage scenario, which could materialize if Gulf LNG exports remain below roughly two-thirds of pre-February 2026 levels through January or a cold winter drives above-average demand. Under that scenario, TTF spot prices could rise to €65–€85/MWh, though prices should remain well below the 2022 and 2023 records of more than €300/MWh. Gas use in power generation is down 5% in Europe and 6% in Northeast Asia since the 2022 crisis began, reducing the global import competition that drove prices to those extremes.

EU storage stands at nearly 60% as of 10 August, the lowest for the date since at least 2021 and well below seasonal norms. Stocks in the Northwest European market region (Belgium, France, Germany, Netherlands), the EU's biggest consuming region, are below 50% full. Italy, the EU's second-largest gas consumer, is nearly 80% full and will likely be adequately supplied this winter. At current LNG import rates of roughly 11 billion cubic meters (bcm) per month, the effective 80% floor is achievable; the 90% target is not.

Demand-side policy measures are likely, even in the basecase. These include restarting mothballed coal-fired units—particularly in Germany—to reduce gas-to-power demand, and deploying Gas Demand Side Response (DSR) mechanisms, where system operators pay industrial and commercial users to cut or halt consumption to protect residential supply. Residential shortages or rationing are extremely unlikely.

The Iran war gas premium will persist. Qatar supplied 7% of EU LNG last winter—4% of total gas imports—and its direct impact is modest. But with Qatari production offline, competing Asian demand is keeping EU import costs elevated. A full Gulf outage would put about 9 bcm per month of gross Gulf LNG exports at risk; each unmet 5 bcm reduces EU storage by roughly five percentage points. Qatari LNG is unlikely to return to full capacity before early 2027. Ongoing Strait of Hormuz disruptions will keep the global gas market tight through at least the end of summer (see note: Iran, MENA Crisis: Escalation likely as Iran sees path to Hormuz control , 15 July 2026). A more benign scenario (10% odds) would require a durable opening of the strait combined with mild winter weather, in which case TTF prices could fall to €30–50/MWh; the El Niño pattern makes a mild winter more likely (see: "Super" El Niño poses growing risks to global commodity markets , 25 July 2026).

The Russian LNG ban will likely take effect on 1 January. Brussels' prohibition removes 13%–15% of EU LNG imports. The European Council extended economic sanctions through 31 July 2027, well past the winter season, and any temporary easing requires a unanimous council decision—placing the probability of full implementation at 80%. If pressure builds for a temporary waiver, Central European states, particularly Slovakia and Czechia, are most likely to break with Brussels first. Holders of legacy contracts can continue moving Russian cargoes to third countries under limited circumstances; frontloading into the EU should be expected in the fourth quarter, followed by rerouting, principally to Asia.

French nuclear generation will be the main source of winter supply stability. Output should remain close to its 2025 level, with heat- and river-related curtailments largely receding by winter. Strong nuclear availability would support exports, reduce gas demand, and help contain prices across interconnected Western European markets. A cold spell that outpaces available nuclear and gas supply would strain supply and push up prices, renewing pressure on governments to provide targeted relief for energy-intensive industries. Hydro-dependent markets in the Nordic, Alpine, and Balkan regions face greater exposure: the hot, dry summer left reservoirs depleted, and autumn rainfall would need to recover substantially to offset the shortfall in flexible supply.

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